

Living Learning Contract

The following Living Learning Contract establishes our shared goals, responsibilities, and working principles for the ABTeC Gallery research and development project. Because the project is exploratory and build upon an existing project, this document may evolve throughout the semester upon client request, as we learn more about the gallery or the strengths and limitations of technologies.

Thesis & Project Brief

The ABTeC Gallery project explores how an existing virtual Indigenous art gallery can be reimaged as a standalone, accessible, and expandable digital exhibition space, free from the limitations of Second Life. We must consider an artist-centered digital exhibition space that preserves the experimental nature and customizability of Second Life while allowing new forms of digital exhibition and transmediation. Sound, interaction, particles, animation, can all become part of how an artwork is experienced.

Final Goal & Scope

Our final goal is rather experimental, reaching not for a finalized prototype, but for a design direction. It should establish a foundation for a new standalone version of the gallery, inspired by existing virtual gallery installations, that can continue to be developed after the current project ends by RAs or in-house staff. Some goals include but are not limited to the following;

- 24/7 accessibility without requiring a host
- Keyboard/mouse access as a baseline for accessibility purposes
- VR support
- Modular architecture using existing 3D models
- Easy integration and replacement of artworks
- Support for models, images, video, text, sound, and interactive works
- Readable text viewing solution
- Flexibility for artists with different levels of technical involvement while considering the high technical aptitudes of the AbTeC team
- Windows, macOS, and browser accessibility where feasible
- Ability to expand if future exhibitions introduce new requirements.

Knowledge Base

The starting knowledge base is a combination of information given to us by the staff, as well as our personal skills and aptitudes.

Nancy outlined that the Gallery began as an “imaginary gallery with real art from her (Skawenatti's) friends”. The gallery exists within a pretense of experimentation with virtual worlds, digital art, Indigenous representation, and online social spaces. The gallery expanded significantly during the COVID-19 pandemic, when additional funding allowed for dedicated 3D modelers and the development of exhibitions such as A Thread That Never Breaks. The project is also informed by spaces such as Elektra Virtual Museum (EVM) and other approaches to presenting art through navigable digital environments.

In our collective exploration of the Second Life platform, we observed several shortcomings, some of which were likewise echoed by Nancy. This includes but is not limited to the following;

- Inability to support complexity
- Inefficient text displays
- Security and privacy concerns
- Dated interface
- Difficult to access important features (Multi-click or hard to find)
- Texture rendering issues
- Limiting for interactive works
- Extremely limiting for sound works
- Poor video quality and lag

These shortcomings inform our prototype heavily by showing us how even a long-term solution can fail, and where we must be vigilant to preserve the user experience. Alternatively, a list of sought after positives were outlined when speaking of Second Life as follows:

- Character customizability
- Web access
- Modular customizable environment
- Multiplayer interactivity
- Free

Learning Objectives:

Technical Proficiency

Due the technical requirements imposed by this project, our team will likely encounter many gaps in knowledge when it comes to our immediate technical abilities. As we move forward many of us will interact with new technologies and new forms of design to circumvent said technical requirements. This will require us to learn new things, and learn to learn new things. Technical proficiency isn't simply the ability to use a piece of technology, it also includes the

ability to know where to look, to scour forums effectively, to seek help and provide it. Through this project we hope to gain certain know-hows we are unaware of at the present time.

Project Management

For some of us on this project, this is our first experience interacting with the real world of project management. It is expected that deadlines will shift, milestones will change, and roadmaps will be discarded and rebuilt. Though not a concrete learning objective, the general experience of Adaptation will likely be a challenge worth confronting.

This would be the section for learning activities, however, due to the current uncertainty on the clients side, it is hard to define activities. Depending on the tools we use, and the general structural demand of the project, we hope to more properly define project activities.

Link to Fizzy: <https://app.fizzy.do/6286150/boards/03gvo16h1y8r1rarh6j7f5yhz>

Milestones:

- Engine exploration - October 8th
 - Our main task is to create a level with Skawenatti's celestial tree inside a building with some movement or interactivity in multiple platforms, presented with pros and cons of each.
 - Unity + Unity web prototype
 - Unreal Engine + UEVR prototype
 - Godot + Godot web prototype
 - One VR example
- 2nd Check in - Late Oct/Early Nov
 - Adding interactivity elements to chosen platform
 - Replicating current exhibit - Shooting the Indian Act
 - Explore different ways of reading text within the platform
- 3rd Check In - End of Semester

Due to this projects nature, a more precise timeline cannot be defined - we are intentionally exploring as we go, seeing what the client likes and expanding from there.

Individual Learning Commitments:

Within the team we have a variety of skillsets that may contribute to the project. Each team member will identify:

Skills I bring to the project:

Skills I want to develop:

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

Areas where I would like support:

Something I want to try:

These commitments may change as the project develops.

Jeremy

Skills I bring to the project:

I come into this project with years of game dev experience, specifically in the Godot game engine. I haven't used Unity in quite some time, but I used to be quite proficient. I also have 10+ years of audio related experience, which I am generalizing since its a very long list of things I can do. I also am a certified Scrum Wizard. That's just a very unserious way to explain what I can offer with the project management sphere.

Skills I want to develop:

I've never used FMOD, so if I get the chance to try it it would be nice. I also want to know more about the gallery and the art on display. ABTeC is fairly new to me, so breaking down my own personal ignorance would be great.

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

Any on offer. My skill set is very multimodal, and any chance to bend myself into a new shape is always accepted. At the moment I don't mind some form of management and sound related items.

Areas where I would like support:

Same as the previous answer, but in addition with coding.

Something I want to try:

As stated in skills I want to develop, FMOD would be a nice to try. I would also love trying out Blender scripting. I've used it for many years, but have never created custom tooling for myself. It would be very interesting to create custom tooling for others.

Ryan

Skills I bring to the project:

My greatest strength is in game design and programming. Particularly game theory and the way that games communicate or convey ideas to players. I have experience in using the game engines Unity, Godot and Monogame. I have some experience developing apps, working with

databases and I know a lot about computers in general. I also do digital artwork and a bit of music.

Skills I want to develop:

I find myself not working in teams very often for these types of projects. So I would like to practice more team oriented skills like communicating and organizing with my peers. I don't make many 3D projects so working in that environment could help me familiarize myself with that environment.

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

I think I am best suited for the hard work of programming and building the project. I know how to navigate and work with game engines well, so I can work efficiently there.

Areas where I would like support:

Accessibility will be an important part of the project. I would like some support to make sure that these features are implemented correctly.

Something I want to try:

I would be interesting to work with VR since I'm very curious about the technology. If I could have an opportunity to work on that, I would like to.

Bea

Skills I bring to the project:

Many, many years doing DIY/grassroots organizing, half a Computer Science degree that has given me knowledge in programming languages such as C++ and Java as well as project management for code-based, collaborative projects and Git workflows. An eye for aesthetics and text layout.

Skills I want to develop:

Working in 3D environments, gaining more knowledge in industry-standard platforms, academic and professional jargon.

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

Would love to help conceptualize creative new forms of interactivity and mod-ability for the platform. Designing interactions both for visitors of the gallery and users/creators/artists/managers of the gallery. Programming things and code legibility.

Areas where I would like support:

Patience learning new software - I've only used Godot and Unity for a small handful of other projects, and never touched Unreal.

Something I want to try:

Working in 3D and doing 3D interactivity/navigation! Big dream would be to create a physical space to go along with a VR gallery display.

Nadia

Skills I bring to the project:

As the only person on this team proficient in Unreal Engine, I must deliver for the prototype so the team has an accurate understanding of the platform. I have worked on similar projects and can manage tasks independently as such. I am mainly a 3D artist and sound designer so all tasks regarding 3D models and sound files will be a strength.

Skills I want to develop:

Despite working on similar projects and on a variety of games, I have not worked within engines that much, so whichever we choose, it will be a learning experience for me. I have also not worked on a successful game project with this many skilled collaborators of similar skillset, I will need to learn to take initiative when appropriate and wear many hats, as we all will.

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

- Environment design
- 3D Model optimization
- 3D integration
- Sound Integration

Areas where I would like support:

Programming, definitely, I am not familiar with GDScript or C++, and have basic C# knowledge, not that I am shying away from it, but if I end up in the weeds, I will need help. I will probably also need reminders for my tasks, like, in-person or text reminders.

Something I want to try:

I want to try VR integration, should we decide to go forward with developing it.

Alex

Skills I bring to the project:

I have worked a lot with Unity and Blender, and I have some client management experience from doing contracts as an independent artist. I am also bringing some management capacity to the table as I have developed some of those skills during game jams. I am also familiar with the academic research environment, as I am currently a research assistant within TAG.

Skills I want to develop:

I want to further develop my coding skills. I also want to learn to work with indigenous artists more, and learn how to be a better help at creating a space in which they can thrive, and learn more about decolonialization.

Areas I would like to take responsibility for:

I would like to take responsibility in some time management, because I think it's an area I need to improve, and I hope to get better at it. I also want to have some coding responsibilities since I have often taken more artistic responsibilities on similar projects.

Areas where I would like support:

If we are using another game engine than Unity, I will need to adapt and may need a few pointers on how things work, and will need to get used to the specifics of coding for that engine.

Something I want to try:

I maybe want to try helping out on sound, or maybe try my hand at a new game engine if we end up choosing something other than Unity.

Collaboration Agreement

As a team, we agree to:

- Communicate technical discoveries or limits
- Document workflows rather than keeping it isolated
- Ask for help when you need it
- Test ideas before making decisions
- Preserve project files and maintain clear versioning/ backups
- Consider accessibility throughout rather than only at the end
- Seek staff input periodically
- Remain attentive to the cultural context and sensitive nature of the work
- Distinguish between an experimental feature and an approved implementation
- Design with future iterations not done by us in mind

Changes to the project are not considered failures, they are part of the research and design process. The purpose of this agreement is to give the team a shared direction while leaving

enough flexibility for the gallery, and our own roles to evolve.

As a team, we all agree to uphold these guidelines to the best of our abilities.

Alexandre Godfroy, Bea Hoekstra, Jeremy Dumont, Ryan Bujold, Nadia Abdul Aziz

Go team ~~